

PURUSHARTHAS

The Four Pillars of Existence

Game Design Document

Version 1.0 | 2026

Engine	Godot 4.x (GDScript)
Platform	PC (Windows / Linux / Mac) — Steam;
Genre	2D Strategy / Simulation — Four Interlocked Layers
Art Style	Hand-illustrated, flat — inspired by Pattachitra and Mughal miniature traditions
Target Audience	18–35 Indian diaspora World history & culture enthusiasts Indie strategy fans
Tone	Contemplative, epic, rooted — not mythological fantasy, but civilisational realism
Solo / Multiplayer	Single-player core; async multiplayer (legacy sharing) in Phase 2

1. Vision Statement

Purusharthas is a 2D strategy and simulation game grounded entirely in the philosophical and civilisational heritage of ancient India. The player does not control a single hero — they steward an entire civilisation across four interlocked modes of existence, each corresponding to one of the four Purusharthas: the classical Indian framework of life's fundamental goals.

The game asks a single central question:

"What does it mean to live — and to govern — rightly?"

There is no single win condition. There is no villain. Progress is measured through legacy, balance, and the flourishing of people, culture, and spirit across generations. This is not a game about conquest — it is a game about civilisational wisdom.

2. Core Concept — The Purushartha Framework

The four Purusharthas — Dharma, Artha, Kama, Moksha — form the structural backbone of the game. Each corresponds to one distinct gameplay layer. Together, they form a unified civilisational ecosystem where decisions in one layer ripple into all others.

Dharma Village Builder Seasonal cycles, Panchayat governance, folk traditions, dharmic community life	Artha Dharmic Governance Kingdom resource management balancing wealth, justice, military, and culture	Kama Civilisation-Lite Dynastic legacy, cultural expansion, trade networks, artistic flourishing	Moksha Pilgrim Route Sim Spiritual economy, temple networks, community care, liberation narratives
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The four layers are not sequential chapters. They run in parallel across a single timeline. A famine in the village layer reduces tax revenue in the governance layer. A pilgrimage surge along the Moksha route boosts morale in the governance layer. A cultural flowering in the Kama layer attracts scholars to the village. Every layer breathes with the others.

3. Gameplay Layers

Layer	Purushartha	Visual Style	Pace	Core Goal
Village Builder	Dharma	2D top-down tile grid	Real-time with seasonal pauses	Grow a self-sufficient gram

Dharmic Governance	Artha	2D kingdom map + advisor panels	Turn-based decisions	Balance four resource axes across a reign
Civilisation-Lite	Kama	2D hex/tile strategy map	Turn-based with event phases	Build a dynasty's cultural legacy
Pilgrim Route Sim	Moksha	2D route/node network	Real-time logistics	Sustain a living spiritual corridor

3.1 Layer I — Village Builder (Dharma)

Concept

The player nurtures a single gram (village) from five families and a well into a self-sufficient, culturally vibrant community. This is the ground layer — the most intimate scale of the game.

Core Loop

- Each in-game year is divided into three seasons: Kharif (monsoon crops), Rabi (winter crops), Zaid (summer cash crops)
- Each season, the player allocates labour across farming, craft production, trade caravans, temple upkeep, and community service
- The Panchayat system: every few years, villagers vote on disputes, infrastructure priorities, and resource allocation — the player may advise or override, but at a trust cost
- Folk events (Holi, harvest festivals, weddings, fairs) require resource investment but yield morale and cultural capital
- Threats: droughts, dacoit raids, debt collectors, disease outbreaks, and migration pressure from nearby towns

Win / Legacy Condition

The village achieves a Gram Swaraj score — a composite of food security, cultural vibrancy, Panchayat trust, and trade connections. High Gram Swaraj unlocks boons in the governance and civilisation layers.

3.2 Layer II — Dharmic Governance Sim (Artha)

Concept

The player rules as a Raja advised by a council of four ministers: the Purohit (spiritual advisor), Senapati (military commander), Amatya (finance minister), and Vaishya (trade representative). Every decision shifts the four Purushartha axes.

Core Loop

- Each reign is divided into decades. Each decade presents a set of events: invasions, droughts, sage arrivals, trade negotiations, internal revolts, or cultural milestones

- The player makes decisions that shift the Dharma / Artha / Kama / Moksha resource axes
- Imbalance creates consequences: too much Artha without Dharma triggers peasant revolt; too much Moksha focus weakens the military; too little Kama leads to cultural stagnation
- Council members have their own loyalty and influence — they can be overruled but at relationship cost
- Succession: the player must groom an heir whose temperament reflects the kingdom's accumulated values

The Four Axes

Axis	Meaning	Boosted By	Neglect Causes
Dharma	Righteousness / Duty	Justice, festivals, sage visits	Unrest, moral decay, revolt
Artha	Wealth / Statecraft	Trade, taxation, infrastructure	Poverty, weak military, collapse
Kama	Fulfilment / Culture	Arts, diplomacy, marriage alliances	Stagnation, cultural erasure
Moksha	Liberation / Spiritual	Temples, ascetics, pilgrimages	Spiritual vacuum, existential crisis

Win / Legacy Condition

At death, the kingdom receives a Legacy Score across all four axes. The score determines how history remembers this reign — and passes inherited advantages or disadvantages to the next generation.

3.3 Layer III — Civilisation-Lite (Kama)

Concept

Zooming out to the dynastic scale, the player guides an ancient Indian dynasty across generations of expansion, diplomacy, and cultural output. This layer operates on a hex-tile regional map of the Indian subcontinent.

Dynasties (Starting Options)

- Maurya — centralised administration, espionage network (Chanakya's Arthashastra mechanics), military dominance
- Gupta — arts, astronomy, mathematics, trade — cultural victory emphasis
- Chola — naval supremacy, Southeast Asian trade routes, temple construction
- Maratha — decentralised confederacy, guerrilla warfare, rapid territorial expansion
- Vijayanagara — southern cultural fortress, art patronage, anti-Sultanate diplomacy

Core Loop

- Turn-based movement and expansion across a hex map
- Each turn: manage diplomacy (alliances, marriages, tribute), military (expansion, defence), and culture (temples, universities, trade guilds)
- Cultural influence spreads through adjacent tiles — language, religion, architecture — even without military conquest
- Rival dynasties pursue their own strategies; the AI models historical patterns of each dynasty
- Victory conditions: military unification, cultural dominance, trade network monopoly, or spiritual supremacy

Win / Legacy Condition

The dynasty achieves one of five victory types: Chakravartin (military), Kalakar (cultural), Vaishya (trade), Dharmaraja (spiritual), or Sarvamangala (balanced — the hardest). Each unlocks unique narrative epilogues.

3.4 Layer IV — Pilgrim Route Sim (Moksha)

Concept

The player manages a network of pilgrimage infrastructure — dharamshalas, ghats, temples, rest houses — along a sacred route connecting four major shrines. This is the most contemplative layer, focused on service, logistics, and spiritual economy.

Core Loop

- Pilgrims arrive with varying needs: rest, food, ritual services, medical care, guidance
- The player hires and manages priests, cooks, palanquin bearers, vaidyas (physicians), and guides
- Seasonal surges — Kumbh, Shravan, Kartik Purnima — overwhelm capacity and require advance preparation
- Route hazards: bandits, floods, monsoon road damage, political unrest in adjacent regions
- Donations and offerings fund upgrades; reputation (Dharma rating of the route) attracts more pilgrims and benefactors
- Miracles: rare random events where extraordinary service yields extraordinary spiritual and material reward

Win / Legacy Condition

The route achieves Tirtha status — a living, breathing sacred corridor that outlasts the player's tenure. A high Tirtha score sends ripples of spiritual energy into all other layers — boosting morale, Dharma axes, and cultural output across the civilisation.

4. Layer Interconnection System

The four layers share a single underlying civilisational state. Events and outcomes in any one layer propagate as modifiers into the others. This creates emergent storytelling without scripted outcomes.

Trigger Layer	→	Effect in Other Layers
Village famine	→	Tax revenues drop in Governance; pilgrim numbers fall on the Route; civilisation expansion slows
Governance passes temple tax exemption	→	Pilgrim Route donations surge; village temple upkeep becomes free; cultural output rises in Civilisation
Civilisation expands to new region	→	New trade goods appear in Village; new pilgrimage destinations unlock on Route; governance gains new province
Pilgrim Route achieves Tirtha status	→	Village morale permanently boosted; Governance Dharma axis rises; Civilisation unlocks sacred architecture
Village Panchayat revolt	→	Governance Artha axis drops; regional instability in Civilisation hex; pilgrim numbers drop on Route

5. Art Direction & Audio

5.1 Visual Style

The visual language of Purusharthas draws from two classical Indian art traditions fused into a single coherent game aesthetic:

- Pattachitra (Odisha) — flat bold outlines, intricate interior patterning, earthy terracotta and indigo palettes — used for the Village layer
- Mughal miniature — detailed architectural rendering, jewel-toned environments, layered depth — used for the Governance and Civilisation layers
- Warli — sparse geometric tribal illustration — used for map overlays, transitions, and loading screens

All four layers share a unified colour palette: deep ochre, indigo, saffron, forest green, ivory, and gold. UI elements are inspired by manuscript marginalia and temple friezes.

5.2 Audio Design

- Village Layer: folk instrumentation — dhol, bansuri, sarangi; ambient sounds of fields, river, market
- Governance Layer: Hindustani classical raga system — raga shifts with time of day, season, and axis balance
- Civilisation Layer: orchestral with Carnatic elements; tempo rises with military conflict, softens with cultural events

- Pilgrim Route Layer: sparse, meditative — Vedic chant samples, temple bells, natural ambience
 - Dynamic audio mixer: the game blends all four soundscapes when switching between layers for a seamless tonal transition
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6. Narrative Architecture

6.1 Framing Device

The game opens and closes with a narrator — a wandering kathakaar (storyteller) — who sits at a crossroads and addresses the player directly. He tells the story of a civilisation across generations, pausing to ask the player what path was chosen and why. This device grounds the game in the oral tradition of Indian storytelling.

6.2 No Binary Morality

Purusharthas deliberately avoids good/evil mechanics. A decision that is correct from an Artha perspective may be problematic from a Dharma lens. The game presents the tension without resolving it — the player must sit with the consequences. This reflects the actual complexity of classical Indian ethical philosophy.

6.3 Historical Texture

- Real historical figures appear as advisors, visitors, or challenges — Chanakya, Adi Shankaracharya, Akka Mahadevi, Chandragupta, Prithviraj Chahamana
 - Real events echo through the game — the Kalinga war's consequences, the Gupta golden age, the Chola naval expeditions
 - All historical references are contextualised with in-game encyclopedia entries accessible at any point
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7. Technical Architecture — Godot 4.x

7.1 Project Structure

- `res://layers/` — four subdirectories, one per Purushartha layer, each self-contained
- `res://core/` — shared civilisational state (GlobalState autoload), event bus, save system
- `res://ui/` — shared UI components: resource bars, notification toasts, advisor panels
- `res://assets/` — art, audio, fonts organised by layer and type

- res://data/ — JSON data files for events, characters, dynasties, buildings, goods

7.2 Core Systems

- GlobalState (Autoload Singleton) — holds the four Purushartha axes and layer states; all four layers read/write to this shared object
- EventBus (Autoload Singleton) — signal relay between layers; decoupled communication
- TileMap System — Village and Civilisation layers use Godot 4's TileMapLayer node with custom tile metadata
- Turn/Season Manager — handles time progression differently per layer (seasons for Village, decades for Governance, eras for Civilisation, years for Pilgrim Route) with a unified global year counter
- SaveSystem — JSON-based save files capturing GlobalState snapshot + per-layer state

7.3 Development Phases

1. Phase 1 — Prototype (3 months): Village Builder standalone, core TileMap, season system, basic Panchayat
2. Phase 2 — Integration (3 months): Governance layer + axis system; first cross-layer event
3. Phase 3 — Expansion (4 months): Civilisation layer + hex map; Pilgrim Route layer
4. Phase 4 — Polish (2 months): Art pass, audio integration, save system, Steam page
5. Phase 5 — Launch: Steam Early Access; gather community feedback for Phase 2 content

8. Market Position & Unique Selling Points

8.1 Market Gap

The global indie strategy market is dominated by European and East Asian historical frameworks. There is no commercially successful 2D strategy game rooted in classical Indian civilisation at this depth. Purusharthas is positioned to own this space entirely.

8.2 Unique Selling Points

- First 2D strategy game to use the Purushartha framework as core game mechanics — not as decoration
- Four interlocked gameplay modes in a single unified world — unusual depth for an indie title

- No Western narrative template: no quest for world domination, no good-vs-evil binary, no hero's journey
- Culturally authentic art, music, and philosophical depth — appeals to Indian diaspora globally
- Educational texture without being didactic — the in-game encyclopedia is optional, never mandatory
- Legacy-based progression — every playthrough generates a unique civilisational story worth sharing

9. Monetisation Strategy

- Base game: one-time purchase on Steam (target: USD 14.99)
- DLC 1 — New Dynasties Pack: adds Pallava, Ahom, and Satavahana dynasties with unique mechanics
- DLC 2 — The Mahabharata Age: a prequel scenario set in the Kuru-Panchala era
- DLC 3 — The Mughal Interface: adds a Sulh-i-Kul (universal peace) governance variant
- Mobile (Phase 2): free-to-play Village Builder layer as standalone mobile entry point; full game as premium unlock
- No pay-to-win, no gacha, no consumable microtransactions — ever

10. Appendix — Key Terminology

Term	Definition
<i>Purushartha</i>	Sanskrit: the four aims of human life — Dharma, Artha, Kama, Moksha
<i>Gram Swaraj</i>	Village self-rule; Gandhian concept of decentralised village governance
<i>Panchayat</i>	Five-member elected village council; traditional Indian local governance body
<i>Kathakaar</i>	Traditional Indian oral storyteller; the game's narrative framing voice
<i>Tirtha</i>	Sacred pilgrimage site; literally a 'crossing point' between the mundane and the divine
<i>Arthashastra</i>	Ancient Indian treatise on statecraft and economic policy, attributed to Chanakya
<i>Chakravartin</i>	Universal sovereign; one who rules righteously over the entire known world

<i>Pattachitra</i>	Traditional Odishan scroll painting style with bold outlines and intricate patterns
<i>Vaidya</i>	Ayurvedic physician; appears in Village and Pilgrim Route layers
<i>Dharamshalas</i>	Rest houses built for pilgrims and travellers along sacred routes

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